# It's

six in the evening in our part of the world when Nilima Sheikh answers a phone call from New York City. The octogenarian artist has just woken up after the opening night of her New York debut, with the exhibition *Fractured Skies* staged at the Museum of Modern Art (MoMA).

It's a show about standing witness to history and the present, which can somehow never outrun the shadows of its past. So, Sheikh chose the title as she can finally feel the sky, a veritable mirror to what happens on the ground. "I've been working with the notion of terrain for quite a long time, and the trauma that the terrain goes through," the artist says, pausing to gather her thoughts. For a moment, she harks back to 'When Champa Grew Up' (1984), her iconic 12-part series in gum tempera on vasli paper, based on the life of a young girl she knew in Baroda, who was later killed in a dowry-related incident. Drawing on Indian miniature traditions and Gujarati women's songs, the intimate sequence traces Champa from childhood and marriage to domestic violence, death and mourning, marking Sheikh's first deliberate use of text in her paintings and a turning point in her narrative practice. With 'Champa', Sheikh stood witness like never before.

As she snaps back to the present, she mulls over all that she's had to behold and then pour it into her art, which is now an essential reading of contemporary Indian culture. "If you think of the violence that happened in 'Champa' or even later, and the violence that happens nowadays on the street, the difference is public acceptance of it and violence becoming a spectacle. Whether it is the rape of an eight-year-old Bakarwal girl or the lynching of Dalits, they're not things that are concealed anymore. These are flaunted in public places," she says. "I think that, for me, this has become one of the biggest causes of anxiety about the way the world is changing."

**SHEIKH'S PAINTINGS DEMAND TO BE SEEN WITH ATTENTION, COMPASSION AND EVEN A BIT OF ALARM. THEIR SCALE AND DETAIL CAN SURPRISE TOO**

In *Fractured Skies*, organised jointly by MoMA and Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA), the throughline is a moment of rupture and disintegration that runs along two decades of Sheikh's career and brings together three bodies of work. 'Each Night Put Kashmir in Your Dreams' (2003–14) is a sequence of double-sided painted scrolls drawing on the province's history, literature, mythology and experiences of displacement and everyday life. It leads into 'Home, Land' (2023–25), which turns to the Bakarwal nomadic communities of Jammu and Kashmir, invoking uncertainty and precarity through horizontal paintings on paper.

The newest work, 'Shahid/Witness' (2025–26), was commissioned by KNMA as 10 gigantic, double-sided scrolls that respond to MoMA's unique layout. Here, the sky is witness to unabated devastation on the planet, with war, migration, surveillance and climate collapse burning through it.

Across the three series, Sheikh draws on casein and mixed tempera, scrolls, stencilling, text and archival research to chart a journey of profound observation and reflection, first focused on the specific histories of Kashmir and eventually zooming out to a larger, global scale of depredation.

Sheikh's art is arresting, in that its scale and detail can often throw a viewer off. Her paintings demand to be seen, perhaps not with curiosity, but with attention, compassion, and



**MIRRORS OF OUR TIMES** An installation view of *Fractured Skies* at the Museum of Modern Art in New York

JONATHAN DORADO